

good in the beginning,” he says.

Kedia runs with a SMILE in the listed space and hunts with CAMP while looking for good start-ups. SMILE is his acronym for Small in size, Medium in experience, Large in aspiration and Extra-large in market potential. For start-ups, CAMP is more accurate: Capabilities of a key person, Market opportunity of the products, and Product’s potential to disrupt the market.

Kedia’s start-up portfolio also showed that, in June 2021, he had invested ₹71.40 lakh in Upside AI, which sought to use machine learning to make investment decisions. The fintech firm shut down in 2023. Later, Upside AI Co-founder Kani-ka Agarrwal explained in a thread on X in December why it failed: “We were growing so quickly that we didn’t see that there is a ceiling on where our products or efforts would take us.... we could have executed better.”

Kedia, who started his investing journey in 1989, believes that the chances of making money as an individual investor while investing in start-ups are very bleak. However, he advises investors to invest in start-ups through funds, as they have professionals who do the research before investing.

JHUNJHUNWALA’S LIMITED PICKS

Even the late Rakesh Jhunjhunwala, who was called the Warren Buffett of India, caught the start-up investing bug. Jhunjhunwala began with a capital of ₹5,000 in 1985; today, his listed portfolio (jointly held with his wife Rekha) is worth nearly ₹50,000 crore. This makes Rekha Jhunjhunwala India’s second biggest individual investor after DMart Founder Radhakishan Damani whose portfolio is worth more than ₹2 lakh crore.

BIG BULL’S PORTFOLIO

LATE RAKESH JHUNJHUNWALA & FAMILY

Company	Holding (in %)	Total Amount Invested
Akasa Air*	37.9	₹223.7 crore
airpay**	43.9	Not Available
The Print#	2	₹5 crore
RezNext	1.1	NA
Medimny##	0.6	₹14.8 lakh

*Rekha Jhunjhunwala owns 34.1% stake; **Rakesh Jhunjhunwala’s brother Rajesh Jhunjhunwala owns 16.8% stake; #Owned by Rekha Jhunjhunwala; ##Owned by Rajesh Jhunjhunwala

NOTE These are not their only investments. They may have other holdings

Data as of May 24, 2024; **Source** Tracxn



Rakesh Jhunjhunwala, a self-made trader, investor and businessman, was also known as the ‘Big Bull’ of D-Street. Data available with Tracxn showed that he was also aggressive in the unlisted and start-up space as he was eyeing sectors such as media and entertainment, aviation, in-house interior designing services, and SaaS players, among others.

However, the Jhunjhunwalas had very limited investment in start-ups. Their first such was in low-cost airline Akasa Air. It was promoted by two aviation industry veterans and had the Jhunjhunwalas as the biggest investor (38%). Jhunjhunwala’s risk was that he was investing in an airline when others were negative on

the sector. During the launch, Jhunjhunwala said, “We have a game plan. It is better to try and fail rather than not try at all.”

Madhusudan Kela, who holds listed shares worth more than ₹2,000 crore, also holds a stake in Akasa Air (0.7%, worth ₹4.5 crore).

Jhunjhunwala and his brother Rajesh together held a 43.9% stake in the integrated omnichannel financial services platform airpay, which was founded in 2012 and has raised \$3.63 million so far. Among his other investments, he acquired a 1.2% stake in Bengaluru-based RezNext in November 2014. RezNext is a SaaS or software as a service platform for hoteliers and channel managers.

Jhunjhunwala, who passed away at age 62 on August 14, 2022, was very bullish on the India growth story. A week before his death, he told an interviewer that India was entering a golden period and could grow at 10% a year.

